1.7 New to teaching visual art in Queensland?

The Queensland context

In Queensland, Visual Art teachers in rural and remote schools are often faced with the dual challenges of being newly graduated and being isolated from peers and from more experienced teachers of the subject. It's important to know how to seek help. First and foremost, it is important to know that the syllabus documents are always the point of truth for teachers, and that you need to build units and teaching programs around them.

Senior schooling

General senior syllabus, Visual Art

Creative Inquiry Second Edition has been written to support teachers who are implementing the General senior syllabus in Visual Art. The General syllabus comprises 4 units of work throughout Years 11 and 12. Teachers develop a course of study using the syllabus. In Year 12, students complete 3 summative internal assessment instruments and 1 external exam.

The QCAA has developed many resources to support teachers in their implementation of the General syllabus. They are available to the general public on the QCAA website. Teachers can also access additional resources on the QCAA portal site.

Alternative sequence

Schools with small cohorts and combined Year 11 and 12 classes might opt to use flexible delivery, such as an Alternative sequence course of study. This approach has the same syllabus objectives and subject matter as the General senior syllabus but where necessary may reorganise subject matter and assessment requirements to ensure comparable complexity across Units 1 and 2 and Units 3 and 4. Schools register with the QCAA to deliver this syllabus. For more information about flexible delivery see the QCE and QCIA handbook on the QCAA website. General senior syllabus resources will support the implementation of the Alternative sequence.

Visual arts in practice syllabus

Visual arts in practice is a syllabus for senior secondary students. It is focused on developing students' knowledge in Visual Art through applied learning, community connections and authentic real-world applications and stimulus. Visual arts in practice comprises 4 units of work throughout Years 11 and 12. Teachers develop a course of study using the Visual arts in practice syllabus. In Year 12, students complete 4 assessments, developed by the school using the assessment specifications and conditions provided in the syllabus.

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Junior schooling

P–10 Australian Curriculum

Depending on the sector you work in (State, Catholic or Independent) there may be different expectations and requirements for the implementation of the Australian Curriculum. Discuss this with your head of faculty or your principal.

The QCAA has a bank of teaching resources for implementing P–10 The Arts (Visual Arts, Dance, Drama, Music, Media Arts) and will continue to build resources to support teachers in their delivery of Australian Curriculum v 9.0. Search the QCAA website to find Visual Arts resources.

Teaching Resources P–10

Resources created to align with previous versions of the Australian Curriculum can always be modified to match the content descriptions and achievement standards in Version 9 and beyond. Sometimes this is a much quicker way to get started with planning than completely reinventing the wheel yourself. However, when you decide to use a unit or lesson plan made by someone else make sure it meets your intentions. If not, modify it and make it your own. Remember you can't assess what you haven't taught, so be thorough in checking that your lesson plans, unit plans, and assessment instruments all align with the unit aims, and achievement standards of the curriculum you are working with.

Professional associations: you're not alone!

Professional associations for Visual Art exist in every state of Australia. In Queensland there are two. They provide support and resources for advocacy, professional learning and teaching. Connecting with the professional association can provide a sense of safety and support even if you are the sole arts teacher in a school.

Queensland Art Teachers Association (QATA)

Queensland Art Teachers Association (QATA) is a significant body that supports Visual Art teachers throughout Queensland. The website links to a range of useful information, events and resources. QATA membership is paid annually. Details are on the website.

- QATA organises regular professional learning events online and in person for members and non-members, including an annual conference in Brisbane. You do not have to be in a metropolitan centre to attend online professional learning.
- The website hosts an advocacy section
- QATA regional cluster groups are a great way to connect up with other Visual Art teachers in your area. You can access more information through the QATA website.
- Importantly, in the members' only section you can access teaching resources made by generous, experienced QATA members.
- QATA hosts Facebook and Instagram pages to allow teachers to connect, support each other and share ideas.

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Peninsula Art Educators Association (PAEA)

PAEA is an active group of Visual Art teachers from Far North Queensland. They connect through Instagram and Facebook. PAEA welcomes art educators from Far North Queensland to share, communicate and exchange Art related ideas. Each year they organise professional learning and exhibition opportunities for teachers.

Queensland regional galleries

Regional galleries provide a valuable site of arts industry connection in coastal and inland areas of Queensland. Connecting with your local gallery can result in opportunities for the growth of your own professional practice and can also benefit your students. Outcomes from getting to know the gallery and gallery staff could result in stimulus experiences, excursions, workshops, networking with community members and meeting teachers from other schools. Some galleries publish learning resources with exhibitions and many store these on their websites. Find out what your closest gallery has available.

Museums and Galleries Queensland have an online search tool to help you locate galleries in your region.

Some useful online curriculum-aligned resources

- State Library of Queensland's Curriculum Connect website has curriculum aligned Visual Art teaching resources for senior and junior classes.
- QAGOMA Learn through Art supports engagement with artworks from the Collection in the classroom and online. Each resource is designed for specific year level groupings with prompts for making and responding.
- National Gallery of Victoria has a suite of digital learning resources which are curriculum aligned and can be adapted to suit learners of different levels.
- National gallery of Australia's diverse learning resources include 'look, think, create' activities, audio and video components, art making projects and much more
- The Institute of Modern Art champions contemporary art, artists, and ideas, connecting local voices to global dialogues via inclusive, sustainable, and innovative institutional practice. IMA curriculum linked resources
- Scootle for digital resources aligned to the Australian Curriculum
- ABC education resources
- Australians Together for First Nations content aligned to curriculum
- Art Education Australia

Other useful resources for Visual Art teaching

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- Art 21 is an organisation producing films and resources based on the belief that the art and ideas of contemporary artists are powerful models for creative and critical thinking across subject areas and disciplines. The content is American.
- The Great Women Artists Instagram and podcasts, with global, historical and contemporary content
- QCAA past units of work that can be adjusted and aligned to the Australian Curriculum v9.0 (Years 1-9)
- Talking with painters podcast has Australian content.
- Art Gallery of NSW – resources that can be adapted to Australian Curriculum and Qld Senior Syllabus
- Google Arts and Culture
- ClickView talk to your school librarian about how ClickView can support your teaching
- acmi online resources and teacher programs for moving image teaching ideas and lesson plans

Advocacy resources

- QCAA has produced posters showcasing the 21st century skills that students learn in the Visual Art. They are currently sitting on the QCAA website in resources for the 2019 syllabus. They are Poster 1: Essential characteristics (School)and Poster 2: Essential characteristics (Students)
- QATA advocacy resources such as stickers, posters and videos. These can be useful at parent-teacher interviews, subject selection events, and displayed in the classroom and around the school.
- National advocates for arts education provide a representative voice that advocates for arts education and curriculum development at the highest political levels, believing that all Australian children have an entitlement to quality arts education across five art forms
- National Association for the Visual Arts
- The Art of Education University- American content but some good ideas. Also, the art of ed podcast
- Outschool,2022, 10 reasons why Visual Arts are important in education. https://info.outschool.com/uk-blog/10-reasons-why-visual-arts-are-important-in-education
- 10 points about art education by Elliott Eisner

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